

EVIDENCE-BASED YOUTH DEVELOPMENT SERIES

The Aspire Way

Soccer Fundamentals, Ages 6–8
A Guide for Volunteer and New Coaches

ASPIRE SPORTS

The Aspire Way: Soccer Fundamentals, Ages 6–8

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First edition

Disclaimer: This guide is intended for educational purposes. Individual results vary; always use age-appropriate judgment and consult qualified coaching resources for your specific players.

Contents

- 1. How Children Learn Soccer5
- 2. The Four Corners19
- 3. The Skills That Matter at 6–821
- 4. Games, Not Drills39
- 5. Your First Sessions69
- 6. Talking to Parents81
- Skill Index91

CHAPTER ONE

How Children Learn Soccer

Before a single drill or drawing of an activity, a coach needs a mental model of the player in front of them. A six-year-old is not a small adult. This chapter lays out how Aspire Sports thinks about the discovery and fundamentals stages of development, and the dozen principles that follow from that thinking.

The Discovery Stage (Ages 3–5)

Introduction to sports through play. Focus on joy, movement, and social interaction.

Let children explore. Every child should touch equipment, move freely, and experience success. No formal instruction—just guided play.

- Fun is the #1 priority
- Free exploration over instruction
- Maximum participation time
- No competition or scores
- Celebrate all effort

Coach's role: Facilitator - Create safe, fun environment for exploration

The Fundamentals Stage (Ages 6–8)

Build basic movement literacy and sport-specific fundamentals through games and activities.

Technique through play. Use small-sided games and activities that naturally develop skills. Avoid lines and lectures.

- Games over drills
- All players touch equipment constantly
- Focus on ABCs: Agility, Balance, Coordination, Speed
- Multi-sport participation strongly encouraged
- Equal playing time for all
- Celebrate improvement, not results

Coach's role: Teacher - Demonstrate, encourage, ask questions instead of lecturing

Practice-to-game ratio: 3:1 · **Max hours/week:** 4

Twelve Principles Coaches Live By

Fun is Non-Negotiable

At ages 6-8, every session must be fun first. If players aren't enjoying themselves, nothing else matters - you'll lose them before skills develop.

Children at this age are sampling activities. They'll continue with what's enjoyable and drop what isn't. Your job is to make them fall in love with the sport.

DO

- Observe faces - are they smiling?
- Use games and competitions they find exciting
- Include silly elements and celebrations
- End on a high note, leaving them wanting more

DON'T

- Prioritize technical perfection over engagement
- Run serious, adult-like training sessions
- Spend time on tactics or formations
- Criticize performance in front of peers

Ajax Amsterdam's youth philosophy states: 'If a child isn't enjoying it, we're doing something wrong.' Fun is considered a prerequisite for development, not a distraction from it.

Play is the Teacher

Games and play-based activities develop skills more effectively than isolated drills. The best learning happens within game contexts.

Skills learned in isolation don't transfer well to games. Skills learned in game-like situations transfer directly. Additionally, play is intrinsically motivating while drills are not.

DO

- Use small-sided games as primary teaching tool
- Design activities that look like the game
- Keep players playing, not waiting in lines
- Adjust games to emphasize target skills

DON'T

- Run drills for half of practice
- Have players standing in lines
- Practice skills without opposition
- Separate technical work from tactical work

Barcelona's La Masia uses 'rondos' (keep-away games) as the foundation of technical training. Game-like pressure creates game-ready skills.

Movement First

Focus on general movement literacy (running, jumping, throwing, catching, balancing) before sport-specific skills. Athletic foundations transfer across all sports.

The best athletes have broad movement vocabularies. Early years should develop coordination, agility, balance, and spatial awareness through varied movements.

DO

- Include activities from other sports
- Use animal movements and crawling patterns
- Incorporate jumping, hopping, skipping
- Challenge balance in fun ways

DON'T

- Focus exclusively on sport-specific skills
- Neglect non-ball activities
- Assume movement skills are already developed
- Skip warmups that build coordination

German sport schools teach 'ABC's of Athleticism' (Agility, Balance, Coordination, Speed) across multiple sports before any specialization occurs.

Every Ball, Every Player

Maximize touches and minimize waiting. Every player should have a ball whenever possible. Lines and waiting kill learning.

Skill development requires repetition. Waiting in lines means missed repetitions. Young players also lose focus when passive.

DO

- Provide enough equipment for all players
- Design activities where everyone moves simultaneously
- Use multiple small groups over one large group
- Keep ball-to-player ratio high

DON'T

- Have half the team watching
- Run passing lines with waiting
- Share balls between many players
- Use activities with long inactive periods

Spanish youth academies use 'technical circuits' where all players work simultaneously on different stations, rotating frequently to maintain engagement and maximize touches.

Questions Over Instructions

Guide players to discover solutions rather than telling them what to do.

When players figure things out themselves, they understand more deeply and retain longer. This approach builds problem-solvers and creative thinkers.

DO

- Ask 'What do you see?' instead of 'Look left!'
- Ask 'What happened there?' instead of 'You should have passed!'
- Let players try solutions before correcting
- Praise the thinking process, not just correct answers

DON'T

- Give step-by-step instructions for every situation
- Stop play constantly to correct mistakes
- Tell players exactly what to do in games
- Praise only correct outcomes

German coaching methodology emphasizes 'guided discovery' where coaches ask questions that lead players to understand concepts themselves.

Game-Based Learning

Learn skills in game-like contexts, not isolated drills.

Players develop faster when skills are practiced in situations that mirror real games. Isolated drills create 'practice players' who can't transfer skills to competition.

DO

- Use small-sided games as the primary teaching tool
- Add decision-making elements to every drill
- Create game situations in practice activities
- Let players experience why a skill matters

DON'T

- Run lines of players taking turns at drills
- Practice skills without any opposition
- Spend entire practices on technique without games
- Separate 'skill work' from 'game play'

Spanish academies use 'rondos' (keep-away games) because they teach passing, receiving, and decision-making all at once in a game context.

Psychological Safety

Create an environment where players feel safe to make mistakes and take risks.

Learning requires mistakes. Players who fear failure play cautiously, avoid risks, and develop more slowly. The best learning environments celebrate creative attempts.

DO

- Celebrate players who try new things (even if they fail)
- Share your own mistakes as a coach
- Use failure as a teaching moment without criticism
- Praise effort and creativity, not just success

DON'T

- Show frustration when players make mistakes
- Single out errors in front of the team
- Pull players for making mistakes in games
- Create pressure situations for young players

Dutch academies have a saying: 'The player who makes no mistakes makes nothing.' Creative players need permission to fail.

Individual Development Paths

Every player develops at their own pace and in their own way.

Development is not linear. Early developers often plateau while late developers catch up. Comparing players to each other ignores natural development variation.

DO

- Track individual progress, not peer comparisons
- Set personalized goals for each player
- Recognize different learning styles
- Be patient with late developers

DON'T

- Rank players against each other
- Cut late-developing players
- Apply same standards regardless of relative age
- Assume current ability predicts future potential

FC Barcelona considers birthdates when evaluating players—a January-born 8-year-old has up to 12 months more development than a December-born teammate.

Development Over Winning

Prioritize individual player development over team results. A successful season is measured by player improvement and enjoyment, not win-loss record.

Youth sports exist to develop people, not to produce trophies. Research shows that development-focused programs produce better players AND more long-term success than win-focused programs.

DO

- Celebrate improvement regardless of game outcome
- Give equal playing time at young ages
- Focus practice on skill development, not just game tactics
- Ask 'Are players getting better?' not 'Are we winning?'

DON'T

- Reduce playing time for weaker players
- Skip skill work to practice set plays
- Judge success solely by standings
- Prioritize winning over player welfare

German youth football banned league standings for under-11s. This removed win pressure and increased development focus. Participation and skill development increased.

Ask, Don't Tell

Use questions to guide player learning rather than giving direct commands. Players who discover solutions develop deeper understanding.

The European coaching approach uses guided discovery. When coaches ask questions instead of giving answers, players develop problem-solving skills and retain learning better.

DO

- Ask 'What did you see?' after a play
- Ask 'What could you try differently?'
- Let players experiment before correcting
- Guide with 'What if...' questions

DON'T

- Give constant play-by-play instructions
- Answer your own questions immediately
- Correct every mistake as it happens
- Lecture during water breaks

Dutch coaching philosophy emphasizes 'coaching without a whistle' - letting the game teach and using questions to prompt reflection rather than stopping play to instruct.

Small-Sided is Superior

Use small-sided games (3v3 to 7v7) for development. They produce more touches, more decisions, and more scoring opportunities than full-field games.

Research shows small-sided games (SSG) create 200-500% more skill execution opportunities than 11v11. They're also more age-appropriate for young players.

DO

- Use 3v3 for 6-8 year olds
- Use 5v5 to 7v7 for 9-12 year olds
- Multiple small games over one big game
- Adjust field size to player age

DON'T

- Play 11v11 with young players
- Use adult-sized goals and fields
- Have half the team as subs watching
- Prioritize positions over play

All major European leagues mandate small-sided games for youth. The English FA requires 5v5 until U10, 7v7 until U12, 9v9 until U14.

Ball Mastery First

Individual ball work (touches, control, moves) is the foundation. Every practice should include dedicated ball mastery time with one ball per player.

Technical excellence starts with comfort on the ball. European academies spend years developing individual technique before tactical complexity.

DO

- Start each session with ball mastery
- One ball per player minimum
- All surfaces (laces, inside, sole, outside)
- Both feet development

DON'T

- Skip individual work for team drills
- Share balls between players
- Only use dominant foot
- Rush to passing/shooting activities

Brazilian futsal produces some of the world's most technically skilled players because youth spend years in small spaces with constant ball contact.

CHAPTER TWO

The Four Corners

Aspire Sports organizes every player's development across four domains. No single one matters more than the others at this age — a confident, coordinated child who can't yet pass accurately is exactly where a six-year-old should be.

Technical

Sport-specific techniques and motor skills. The physical execution of movements required for the sport.

Weight in overall assessment: 30% · **Assessed:** monthly

Tactical

Decision-making, game understanding, and strategic awareness. Reading the game and making good choices.

Weight in overall assessment: 25% · **Assessed:** monthly

Physical

Athletic abilities: speed, agility, strength, endurance, coordination, and flexibility.

Weight in overall assessment: 25% · **Assessed:** per season

Psychological

Mental skills: confidence, focus, resilience, coachability, teamwork, and competitive mindset.

Weight in overall assessment: 20% · **Assessed:** per season

CHAPTER THREE

The Skills That Matter at 6–8

These are the 18 skills Aspire Sports tracks for the fundamentals stage, grouped by domain. Each includes a five-level progression so you can recognize where a player is now — not to sort players, but to know what to say next.

Technical

Ball Control

TECHNICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to keep the ball close and under control while stationary and moving. Foundation skill that enables all other technical abilities.

1	Ball frequently escapes; requires multiple touches to control; often loses possession
2	Can control ball when stationary; loses control when moving; inconsistent touch
3	Maintains control while jogging; can change direction with ball; occasional loss of control under pressure
4	Controls ball at speed; uses both feet; maintains control with defender nearby
5	Exceptional close control in tight spaces; creative touches; rarely loses possession

COACHING PROMPTS

- What happened when you stopped the ball with your toe? What about your inside foot?
- Can you make your foot 'soft like a pillow' to catch the ball? What did you notice?
- Where did you want the ball to go after you controlled it? Did it go there?
- Which part of your foot did you use? What made you choose that one?

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- The ball bouncing away is totally normal - controlling a moving ball is genuinely difficult!
- Using the toe is natural at first - the inside foot habit develops with practice
- Stiff-legged receiving is common - the cushioning motion takes time to learn

Ball Mastery - Toe Taps

TECHNICAL · CORE SKILL

Alternating toe taps on top of the ball with control and rhythm

-
- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Struggles to tap ball; loses balance frequently; ball rolls away after each attempt |
|---|---|
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- | | |
|---|---|
| 2 | Can perform slow toe taps; needs to stop and reset often; rhythm inconsistent |
|---|---|
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- | | |
|---|--|
| 3 | Performs toe taps with steady rhythm; maintains balance; can sustain for 20+ seconds |
|---|--|
-
- | | |
|---|---|
| 4 | Quick, rhythmic toe taps with eyes up; can move around the ball; confident alternating feet |
|---|---|
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- | | |
|---|---|
| 5 | Effortless toe taps at high speed; incorporates variations; maintains rhythm while scanning |
|---|---|
-

COACHING PROMPTS

- What happens to your balance when you bend your knees a little more?
- Can you feel the top of the ball with your toes without looking?
- How light can you make your touches while still staying in control?
- What do you notice when you try to tap faster - where does the ball go?

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Stepping on ball instead of tapping top
- Standing too upright (losing balance)
- Looking down at feet throughout

Passing (Short)

TECHNICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to accurately deliver the ball to a teammate over short distances (under 15 yards) using the inside of the foot.

1	Passes lack direction and weight; uses toe or random foot surface
2	Can pass stationary ball to stationary target; inconsistent accuracy
3	Passes moving ball accurately to stationary teammate; appropriate weight
4	Passes accurately to moving teammate; uses both feet; consistent technique
5	Disguised passes; perfect weight; can execute under pressure

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'Lock your ankle' - foot stays firm like a hockey stick
- 'Point your belly button' at your target
- 'Pass to their front foot' - lead a moving teammate
- 'Use the flat part' - show inside of foot like high-five

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Using toe to pass (ball bounces unpredictably)
- Non-kicking foot pointing wrong direction
- No follow-through (stabbing at ball)

Receiving / First Touch

TECHNICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to control an incoming ball and prepare it for the next action (pass, dribble, or shot). The most important touch in soccer.

-
- | | |
|----------|--|
| 1 | Ball bounces away on first touch; cannot control pace of incoming ball |
|----------|--|
-
- | | |
|----------|---|
| 2 | Can stop ball but it stays under feet; needs multiple touches |
|----------|---|
-
- | | |
|----------|--|
| 3 | Controls ball into space with first touch; body opens to field |
|----------|--|
-
- | | |
|----------|---|
| 4 | First touch sets up next action; can receive under pressure |
|----------|---|
-
- | | |
|----------|---|
| 5 | Creative first touch; deceives defenders; controls any ball |
|----------|---|
-

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'Soft feet like pillows' - cushion the ball
- 'Open your body' - show where you want to go
- 'Touch it forward' - not under your feet
- 'Check your shoulder' - look before it arrives

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Stiff leg (ball bounces away)
- Trapping ball directly under feet
- Not looking before receiving

Dribbling with Inside/Outside

TECHNICAL · CORE SKILL

Moving with the ball using inside and outside of both feet

1	Ball escapes frequently; uses only one surface; cannot change direction; stops to control
2	Can dribble slowly using inside; beginning to use outside; changes direction with difficulty
3	Smooth inside/outside touch at jogging pace; changes direction fluidly; maintains ball close
4	Quick direction changes using both surfaces; beats defenders; executes at speed under pressure
5	Elite close control with deceptive touches; creates space effortlessly; artistic ball manipulation

COACHING PROMPTS

- Can you feel the difference between touching with the inside versus outside?
- What happens to the defender when you quickly change the direction of the ball?
- How close can you keep the ball while still moving forward?
- Which foot feels more comfortable - let's practice the other one too!

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Only using inside of foot
- Pushing ball too far when changing direction
- Stopping to switch from inside to outside

Dribbling

TECHNICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to move with the ball while maintaining control, including changes of speed, direction, and using moves to beat opponents.

- | | |
|----------|---|
| 1 | Kicks ball ahead and chases; no control while moving |
| 2 | Can dribble slowly in straight line; struggles with direction changes |
| 3 | Dribbles at jogging pace with direction changes; can use basic moves |
| 4 | Dribbles at speed; uses multiple moves; beats defenders |
| 5 | Creative dribbling; unpredictable; beats multiple defenders |

COACHING PROMPTS

- What happens when you kick the ball harder? What about a softer touch?
- Can you peek up and tell me what color shirt I'm wearing while you dribble?
- Which part of your foot are you using? What happens if you try a different part?
- Where's an open space you could dribble to? Show me!

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- It's common for the ball to escape - every player works on this throughout their career!
- Players often use only their toe at first - other foot surfaces develop with practice
- Looking at the ball constantly is natural - head-up dribbling builds over time

Shooting

TECHNICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to strike the ball toward goal with power, accuracy, and appropriate technique.

1	Shots weak and inaccurate; often misses target completely; technique inconsistent
2	Can shoot on target from close range; power developing; technique improving
3	Shoots with power and accuracy; can shoot moving ball; makes good decisions
4	Powerful, accurate shots in game situations; variety of techniques; confident finisher
5	Elite finishing ability; clinical with both feet; creates and converts chances; natural scorer

COACHING PROMPTS

- Where is the goal - did you look before you shot?
- What happens to the ball when you lean over it versus lean back?
- Can you pick your spot before shooting?
- Which part of your foot gives you power? Which gives placement?

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Using toe to shoot
- Leaning back (ball goes high)
- Planting foot too far from ball

Tactical

Finding Space

TACTICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to position oneself in open areas to receive the ball, create passing options, and contribute to team play.

- | | |
|----------|---|
| 1 | Follows the ball everywhere; bunches with teammates; no awareness of space |
| 2 | Beginning to spread out when reminded; occasionally finds space |
| 3 | Finds open space consistently; shows for ball; understands width/depth basics |
| 4 | Creates space through movement; times runs well; reads game situation |
| 5 | Manipulates space; creates options for teammates; advanced tactical awareness |

COACHING PROMPTS

- Where is nobody standing right now? Can you go there?
- If you were the ball, could you see your teammate from there?
- What happens when everyone bunches together? Is there room to play?
- You passed the ball - now what? Where's a good spot to move to?

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Clustering around the ball is completely natural for young players - they're drawn to the action!
- Standing still when off the ball is common - movement awareness develops with experience
- Moving to obvious spaces only is a natural starting point - reading space develops over time

Support Play

TACTICAL

The ability to provide passing options and help for the teammate with the ball through positioning, communication, and movement.

1	Watches teammate; provides no support; no awareness of helping
2	Occasionally moves to help; support distance wrong; minimal communication
3	Provides consistent support option; good distance; calls for ball
4	Creates multiple options; adjusts angle based on pressure; combines effectively
5	Always available; organizes support play; creates overloads

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'Give them an option!' - always be available
- 'Show at an angle!' - so you can see forward
- 'Right distance!' - not too close, not too far
- 'Call for it!' - let them know you're there

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Standing watching the play
- Supporting too close (congests space)
- Supporting too far (pass too difficult)

1v1 Defending

TACTICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to stop an attacker in individual situations through proper positioning, patience, and tackling technique.

-
- | | |
|----------|---|
| 1 | Dives in immediately; easily beaten; no defensive shape |
| 2 | Shows some patience; body position improving; still often beaten |
| 3 | Stays balanced; forces attacker wide; wins some challenges |
| 4 | Consistently delays attacker; reads their intentions; wins majority of 1v1s |
| 5 | Dominant 1v1 defender; anticipates moves; rarely beaten |
-

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'Get goalside!' - always between attacker and goal
- 'Patience!' - don't dive in
- 'On your toes!' - stay bouncy, ready to move
- 'Show them the line!' - force them wide

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Diving in immediately (lunging)
- Standing flat-footed
- Square to attacker (can go either way)

Physical

Agility - Change of Direction

PHYSICAL · CORE SKILL

Ability to quickly change direction while running

1	Slow direction changes, loses balance
2	Can change direction but slows significantly
3	Smooth direction changes at moderate speed
4	Quick direction changes, maintains speed
5	Explosive changes, can fake and deceive

COACHING PROMPTS

- Bend your knees
- Small quick steps before changing
- Push off the outside foot

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Standing too tall
- Crossing feet
- Losing balance

Agility & Coordination

PHYSICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to change direction quickly, maintain balance, and coordinate multiple body parts effectively during movement.

- | | |
|----------|--|
| 1 | Uncoordinated movement; struggles with balance; slow direction changes |
| 2 | Basic coordination developing; can change direction with planning |
| 3 | Good body control; changes direction quickly; maintains balance in most situations |
| 4 | Excellent agility; quick feet; maintains control at speed |
| 5 | Elite movement ability; exceptional balance; explosive direction changes |

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'Get low!' - bend knees for direction changes
- 'Push off!' - drive off outside foot
- 'Arms help!' - pump arms for balance and power
- 'Quick feet!' - small fast steps when needed

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Standing upright when changing direction
- Crossing feet (leads to falling)
- Arms not helping movement

Speed

PHYSICAL

The ability to move quickly over short distances, including acceleration, top speed, and speed with the ball.

1	Slow relative to peers; poor running technique; slow acceleration
2	Average speed; developing technique; improving acceleration
3	Good speed; efficient running form; quick acceleration
4	Fast relative to peers; excellent technique; explosive starts
5	Exceptionally fast; elite sprinting ability; speed is a weapon

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'Arms drive the legs!' - pump those arms
- 'Drive those knees!' - high knee action
- 'Lean forward!' - fall into your sprint
- 'Push the ground away!' - drive off the ground

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Arms across body (not driving forward)
- Short choppy strides
- Running upright when accelerating

Psychological

Enjoyment of Play

PSYCHOLOGICAL

Confidence

PSYCHOLOGICAL · CORE SKILL

The belief in one's own abilities to perform skills, take on challenges, and recover from mistakes during play.

- | | |
|----------|---|
| 1 | Hesitant to try; avoids ball; gives up easily; needs constant encouragement |
| 2 | Will try with encouragement; affected by mistakes; inconsistent confidence |
| 3 | Tries most things willingly; recovers from some mistakes; generally positive |
| 4 | Takes on challenges readily; resilient to setbacks; believes in abilities |
| 5 | Supremely confident; inspires others; thrives under pressure; welcomes challenges |

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'You can do it!' - genuine encouragement
- 'Great effort!' - praise the try, not just success
- 'Mistakes help us learn!' - normalize errors
- 'That's brave!' - acknowledge courage to try

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Avoiding the ball or challenges
- Negative self-talk ('I can't do this')
- Hiding during activities

Coachability

PSYCHOLOGICAL · CORE SKILL

Receptiveness to instruction, feedback, and trying new things

1	Resistant to feedback, doesn't try new things
2	Listens but struggles to apply feedback
3	Accepts feedback and attempts to implement
4	Actively seeks feedback, applies it quickly
5	Self-corrects, asks questions, loves learning

COACHING PROMPTS

- Catch them doing something right
- Make feedback specific and immediate
- Ask what they noticed

Resilience

PSYCHOLOGICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to recover from setbacks, handle adversity, and persist through challenges in sport and competition.

1	Gives up at first difficulty; overwhelmed by setbacks; cannot self-regulate
2	Recovers slowly from setbacks; needs support to continue; struggles with losing
3	Handles most setbacks; recovers reasonably quickly; learning to manage emotions
4	Bounces back quickly; uses setbacks as motivation; manages emotions well
5	Thrives on adversity; inspires others in tough moments; exceptional emotional control

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'Keep going!' - encourage persistence
- 'Mistakes are how we learn!' - reframe errors
- 'Take a breath' - help with emotional regulation
- 'What can we do differently?' - solution focus

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Stopping trying after errors
- Crying/tantrum after setbacks
- Blaming others for failures

Teamwork

PSYCHOLOGICAL · CORE SKILL

The ability to work cooperatively with teammates, communicate effectively, and prioritize team success over individual achievement.

1	Plays alone; doesn't pass or cooperate; unaware of teammates
2	Beginning to include teammates; passes sometimes; aware of others
3	Works well with teammates; shares ball; celebrates others' success
4	Strong collaborator; encourages teammates; team-first mentality
5	Team leader; elevates others; exceptional communication; selfless

COACHING PROMPTS

- 'We're a team!' - emphasize collective
- 'Great pass!' - praise teamwork moments
- 'Help your teammate!' - encourage support
- 'How can you include everyone?' - shared responsibility

NORMAL AT THIS AGE

- Ball-hogging
- Getting upset when not passed to
- Blaming teammates for mistakes

CHAPTER FOUR

Games, Not Drills

Every one of these 23 activities teaches a skill from Chapter Three through play, not repetition. Run them as written first; the variations exist for when your group needs more or less challenge.

2v2 with Mini Goals

BEGINNER · 4–12 PLAYERS · 12 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Intense 2v2 game with goals at each end

1. 2v2 games to 3 goals 2. Winners stay on, losers rotate 3. Or play round robin tournament 4. Focus on individual skills and basic combinations

Equipment: Mini goals or cones, Pinnies, Balls

COACHING POINTS

- Support your partner
- Quick decisions
- Take on 1v1 situations
- Communicate

COMMON MISTAKES

- Both going to ball
- Not supporting partner
- Forcing shots

Variations: Four Goals (Each team can score in two goals); Touch Limit (Maximum 3 touches per player)

MAKE IT EASIER

Larger field, bigger goals

MAKE IT HARDER

Smaller field, touch restrictions

3v1 Rondo

BEGINNER · 4–12 PLAYERS · 10 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Classic possession game to develop quick passing and movement

1. Three players on outside try to keep the ball 2. Defender in middle tries to win ball or force it out 3. If defender wins ball, they swap with player who lost it 4. Count consecutive passes - try to beat your record

Equipment: Cones, Balls, Pinnies optional

COACHING POINTS

- Move after you pass
- Create passing angles
- Play one or two-touch
- Communicate with teammates

COMMON MISTAKES

- Standing still after passing
- Passing to feet instead of space
- Taking too many touches

Variations: 4v1 (Four outside players for easier possession); 3v2 (Two defenders for more pressure)

MAKE IT EASIER

Larger box, 4v1 instead of 3v1

MAKE IT HARDER

Smaller box, 3v2, one-touch only

3v3 Line Soccer

BEGINNER · 6–12 PLAYERS · 12 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Score by dribbling over end line instead of into goal

1. 3v3 teams try to dribble across opponent's end line
2. Ball must be under control when crossing line
3. After goal, other team starts with ball
4. Encourages dribbling and width

Equipment: Cones, Pinnies, Balls

COACHING POINTS

- Use the full width
- Recognize when to dribble vs pass
- Attack spaces, not defenders
- Transition quickly

COMMON MISTAKES

- Too narrow - everyone in middle
- Forcing through defenders
- Slow transition

Variations: Wide Zones (Create wide channels worth bonus points);
Must Receive (Must receive pass over line (not dribble))

MAKE IT EASIER

Wider field, larger end zones

MAKE IT HARDER

Narrower field, must receive in end zone

Ball Mastery Circle

BEGINNER · 4–20 PLAYERS · 8 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Players form a circle around the coach who demonstrates ball mastery moves. Everyone practices together, building foundational touches and footwork in a supportive, follow-the-leader format.

Equipment: 1 ball per player

COACHING POINTS

- **LIGHT TOUCHES** → Say: 'Touch the ball like it's a balloon - too hard and it pops!'
- **BALL STAYS STILL** → Say: 'The ball should stay in your space, not roll away!'
- **BALANCE ON STANDING FOOT** → Say: 'Strong tree trunk leg! The other foot dances!'
- **EYES UP OCCASIONALLY** → Say: 'Can you do it without looking? Sneaky feet!'

COMMON MISTAKES

- **BALL ROLLING AWAY** → Say: 'Softer touch! Pretend the ball is a sleeping baby'
- **LOSING BALANCE** → Say: 'Arms out like an airplane for balance!'
- **WRONG FOOT SURFACE** → Say: 'Let me see that part of your foot touch - yes! The bottom!'
- **GOING TOO FAST** → Say: 'Slow is smooth, smooth is fast. Start slow, speed up later!'

Variations: Mirror Partners (Pair up - one leads, one copies. Switch every 30 seconds.); Music Moves (Play music - when it stops, freeze with ball under foot.); Player Demo (Ask a player to show their favorite move to the group.); Combo Sequences (Create patterns: 3 toe taps, 2 sole rolls, 4 tick-tocks.)

MAKE IT EASIER

SIGNS THEY'RE STRUGGLING:

- Balls constantly rolling away

- Falling off balance frequently
- Frustrated expressions
- Not keeping up with demos

SOLUTIONS:

- Slow down demonstrations significantly
- Only teach 2 moves instead of 4
- Allow ball to move a little (don't require stationary)
- Let them sit on ball to practice balance first
- Use larger, slightly deflated balls (easier control)

MAKE IT HARDER

SIGNS THEY'RE READY:

- Completing all moves perfectly
- Looking bored
- Asking "what else can we do?"
- Finishing before others

SOLUTIONS:

- Speed up the moves
- Add weak foot requirement
- Eyes closed challenge
- Combine moves into sequences
- Add movement (circle while doing toe taps)
- Player becomes demonstrator

Ball Tag

BEGINNER · 8–24 PLAYERS · 8 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Fun conditioning game where everyone dribbles while playing tag

1. Everyone dribbles inside the grid, including taggers 2. Taggers try to tag other players while dribbling 3. If tagged, do 10 ball taps and return to the game 4. Rotate taggers every 90 seconds

Equipment: Cones, 1 ball per player, Pinnies

COACHING POINTS

- Keep ball close while looking around
- Change direction suddenly to escape
- Use your body to shield
- Stay alert - know where taggers are

COMMON MISTAKES

- Losing the ball while running
- Not keeping head up

Variations: Freeze Ball Tag (Tagged players freeze, can be freed by another player passing through their legs)

MAKE IT EASIER

Fewer taggers, larger grid

MAKE IT HARDER

More taggers, smaller grid

Copy Cat Dribbling

BEGINNER · 4–20 PLAYERS · 6 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Follow the leader dribbling game where players mirror the coach or leader

1. Players dribble following the leader
2. Leader performs different moves - players copy
3. Include: speed changes, direction changes, stops, turns
4. Rotate leader every 60-90 seconds

Equipment: 1 ball per player

COACHING POINTS

- Keep ball close while watching leader
- Quick reactions
- Use different parts of foot

COMMON MISTAKES

- Watching only the ball
- Getting too far behind

Variations: Freeze Copy (Must freeze in exact same position as leader)

MAKE IT EASIER

Slower pace, simpler moves

MAKE IT HARDER

Faster pace, complex combinations

Dribblers vs Defenders

BEGINNER · 10–24 PLAYERS · 12 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Mass 1v1 game where dribblers try to cross the field

1. All dribblers try to reach the other end line 2. Defenders try to kick balls out 3. If your ball is kicked out, you join the defenders 4. Last dribbler remaining is the winner 5. Play multiple rounds

Equipment: Cones, 1 ball per dribbler

COACHING POINTS

- Use moves to beat defenders
- Change speeds
- Protect the ball with body
- Find open lanes

COMMON MISTAKES

- Running into defenders
- Not shielding
- Going too fast without control

Variations: British Bulldog (If tagged (not ball kicked), you become defender); Safe Zones (Add 'safe zones' where defenders can't enter)

MAKE IT EASIER

Wider field, fewer defenders

MAKE IT HARDER

Narrower field, more defenders

End Zone Game

BEGINNER · 8–16 PLAYERS · 15 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Possession game where teams score by dribbling into end zone

1. Teams try to dribble ball under control into opponent's end zone 2. Must be in control of ball when entering end zone to score 3. After a score, other team gets ball from their end zone 4. No goalkeepers - all outfield players

Equipment: Cones, Pinnies, Balls

COACHING POINTS

- Width in attack
- Quick ball circulation
- Recognize when to dribble vs pass
- Support the ball carrier

COMMON MISTAKES

- Rushing into end zone without control
- Not spreading out
- Everyone chasing the ball

Variations: Receive in End Zone (Must receive pass in end zone (not dribble) to score); Time Limit (Must score within 30 seconds or lose possession)

MAKE IT EASIER

Wider field, larger end zones

MAKE IT HARDER

Smaller end zones, add neutral player for defending team

Gates Dribbling

BEGINNER · 4–24 PLAYERS · 8 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Players dribble through randomly scattered cone 'gates' throughout a playing area. Develops dribbling with head up, direction changes, spatial awareness, and decision-making about which gate to attack next.

Equipment: 1 ball per player, 10-16 cones

COACHING POINTS

- HEAD UP → Say: 'Eyes up! Where's your next gate?'
- BALL CLOSE THROUGH GATE → Say: 'Ball stays with you through the gate - like walking your dog through a door!'
- CHANGE DIRECTION → Say: 'Don't just go straight - curve toward your next gate!'
- PLAN AHEAD → Say: 'Look for your next gate WHILE going through this one!'

COMMON MISTAKES

- STARING AT BALL → Say: 'Quick peeks at the ball, long looks ahead!'
- KICKING THROUGH AND CHASING → Say: 'Ball stays at your feet - don't kick ahead!'
- ALL GOING TO SAME GATE → Say: 'Find your own gate! Look for empty ones!'
- GOING BACK THROUGH SAME GATE → Say: 'New gate each time! Explore everywhere!'

Variations: Partner Gates (Work in pairs - pass ball through gate to partner. Count combined gates.); Color Gates (Different colored cone gates worth different points. Red=3, Yellow=2, Green=1.); Gate Keeper (1-2 players defend gates. Dribblers score by going through unguarded gates.); Sequence Gates (Must go through gates in order (numbered or colored sequence).)

MAKE IT EASIER

SIGNS THEY'RE STRUGGLING:

- Ball always escaping through gates
- Can't find gates (head down)
- Collisions at gates
- Low gate counts (less than 3 per minute)

SOLUTIONS:

- Make gates wider (3 paces instead of 2)
- Fewer gates but more spread out
- Walk-through allowed (not just dribble)
- Coach stands at gate calling them over
- Allow ball to go through slightly ahead

MAKE IT HARDER

SIGNS THEY'RE READY:

- Easily getting 10+ gates per minute
- Head always up
- No collisions
- Looking bored

SOLUTIONS:

- Narrower gates (1.5 paces)
- Must go AROUND cone not between sometimes
- Weak foot only
- Add a gate keeper defender
- Can't use same gate twice in a row
- Specify exit directions

Juggling Challenge

INTERMEDIATE · 4–24 PLAYERS · 10 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Progressive juggling skills building ball control

Challenge progression: 1. Drop and catch (one bounce between) 2. Two touches then catch 3. Thigh, foot, catch 4. Non-stop foot juggles (count personal best) 5. Alternating feet only

Equipment: 1 ball per player

COACHING POINTS

- Soft touch - ball goes up, not away
- Point toe slightly up
- Small touches
- Stay balanced on standing leg

COMMON MISTAKES

- Kicking too hard
- Toe pointed down
- Leaning back

Variations: Partner Juggling (Juggle back and forth with partner); Sit and Juggle (Seated juggling with feet only)

MAKE IT EASIER

Allow bounces between touches

MAKE IT HARDER

No bounces, add thigh/head, movement while juggling

King of the Ring

BEGINNER · 6–16 PLAYERS · 10 MIN · SMALL SPACE

1v1 competition to knock opponents' balls out of circle

1. Everyone dribbles in the circle 2. Try to kick others' balls out while protecting yours 3. If your ball goes out, do 10 toe taps and return 4. Last one with ball in circle is 'King'

Equipment: Cones, 1 ball per player

COACHING POINTS

- Protect your ball with body
- Head up to see opponents
- Timing of challenges
- Use your body to shield

COMMON MISTAKES

- Ball too far from body
- Only focused on attacking
- Not shielding

Variations: No Re-entry (If knocked out, you're out for round); Partners (Play as pairs - protect each other)

MAKE IT EASIER

Larger circle, must stop ball before returning

MAKE IT HARDER

Smaller circle, no re-entry

Musical Balls

BEGINNER · 8–24 PLAYERS · 7 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Soccer version of musical chairs - when music stops, find a ball!

1. Players jog/skip around the grid while music plays 2. When music stops, find a ball and perform a move (toe taps) 3. Player without a ball does 5 jumping jacks 4. Remove one ball each round until final two players

Equipment: Balls (one fewer than players), Music speaker

COACHING POINTS

- Stay light on your feet
- Be aware of space around you
- React quickly to the music

COMMON MISTAKES

- Standing too far from balls
- Not paying attention

Variations: Skills Challenge (Must complete 10 toe taps to 'claim' the ball)

MAKE IT EASIER

Fewer balls removed each round

MAKE IT HARDER

More balls removed, smaller grid

Numbers Game Warmup

BEGINNER · 6–24 PLAYERS · 7 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Coach calls numbers for different movements while dribbling

Number commands: 1 = Stop ball with sole 2 = Speed dribble 3 = Turn around (any turn) 4 = Change direction (cut) 5 = Do a skill move Players dribble freely, coach calls numbers.

Equipment: 1 ball per player, Cones for grid

COACHING POINTS

- React quickly to numbers
- Keep ball under control
- Practice different skills on command

COMMON MISTAKES

- Forgetting the numbers
- Slow reactions

Variations: Player Caller (A player becomes the number caller); Add Colors (Use both numbers and colors for different actions)

MAKE IT EASIER

Fewer numbers (1-3 only)

MAKE IT HARDER

More numbers, faster calling, add combinations

Partner Stretching

BEGINNER · 4–24 PLAYERS · 8 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Cool down with partner-assisted stretching

Stretch each 30 seconds: 1. Seated hamstring (partner gently pushes back) 2. Calf stretch against partner 3. Quad stretch with partner balance 4. Groin stretch (soles together, partner presses knees) 5. Back twist with partner support 6. Shoulder stretch with partner assist

Equipment: None required

COACHING POINTS

- Gentle pressure - no bouncing
- Breathe deeply
- Communicate with partner
- Hold stretches, don't bounce

COMMON MISTAKES

- Pushing too hard
- Bouncing stretches
- Holding breath

Variations: Ball Stretches (Use ball in some stretches)

MAKE IT EASIER

Less time per stretch

MAKE IT HARDER

Longer holds, more stretches

Passing Accuracy Challenge

BEGINNER · 4–16 PLAYERS · 10 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Hit targets with passes to score points

1. Players line up with balls 2. Pass through gates to score points 3. Narrow gate = 3 points, medium = 2 points, wide = 1 point 4. Each player gets 5 attempts, most points wins

Equipment: Cones, Balls

COACHING POINTS

- Plant foot pointing at target
- Lock ankle, strike through middle of ball
- Follow through toward target

COMMON MISTAKES

- Toe poking
- Not following through
- Looking up too early

Variations: Moving Target (Partner moves side to side as target); Weak Foot Only (All passes with non-dominant foot)

MAKE IT EASIER

Wider gates, closer distances

MAKE IT HARDER

Narrower gates, further distances, add time limit

Passing Pairs

BEGINNER · 4–24 PLAYERS · 6 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Simple partner passing to cool down and focus on technique

1. Pass back and forth, focusing on technique 2. Receive with inside of foot, pass with inside 3. Two touches: one to control, one to pass 4. Switch to different passes: outside of foot, driven pass

Equipment: 1 ball per pair

COACHING POINTS

- Lock ankle when passing
- Follow through to target
- Soft first touch
- Communicate with partner

COMMON MISTAKES

- Ankle not locked
- Toe poking the ball

Variations: One Touch (Challenge to play one-touch passes)

MAKE IT EASIER

Closer together

MAKE IT HARDER

Farther apart, one-touch only

Shark Attack

BEGINNER · 6–24 PLAYERS · 7 MIN · SMALL SPACE

High-energy dribbling game where players protect their balls from 'sharks' who try to kick them out. Develops dribbling under pressure, awareness, and shielding in a fun, game-like environment.

Builds: Ball Control

Equipment: 1 ball per player, 4 cones, 2-3 pinnies

COACHING POINTS

- HEAD UP while dribbling → Say: 'Can you dribble AND see the shark at the same time?'
- USE BODY to shield → Say: 'Put your body between the shark and your ball - like protecting your lunch!'
- SMALL touches → Say: 'Keep the ball close, like it's on a short leash!'
- CHANGE DIRECTION → Say: 'When the shark gets close, can you turn away?'

COMMON MISTAKES

- KICKING BALL TOO FAR → Say: 'Tiny touches! Ball should never be more than one step away'
- ONLY WATCHING BALL → Say: 'Quick peeks up! Look at ball, look up, look at ball, look up'
- RUNNING WITHOUT BALL → Say: 'Take your ball with you when you escape!'
- SHARKS CHASING ONE PLAYER → Say: 'Sharks, look for easy targets - who's not paying attention?'

Variations: Freeze Sharks (When coach yells 'FREEZE!' everyone stops. Last moving becomes shark.); Ball Thief (Sharks steal and dribble instead of kicking out. More 1v1 battles.); Shark Jail (If caught, you become a shark too. Last dribbler wins!); Superhero Rescue (Player with ball can 'rescue' frozen teammate by passing to them.)

MAKE IT EASIER

SIGNS THEY'RE STRUGGLING:

- Most balls knocked out within 30 seconds
- Players looking frustrated, not smiling
- No one can escape sharks

SOLUTIONS:

- Make grid bigger (25x25 paces)
- Fewer sharks (1 shark per 6-7 dribblers)
- Sharks must hop instead of run
- Allow 3 toe taps instead of 5
- "Safe zones" in corners (can't be tagged for 3 seconds)

MAKE IT HARDER

SIGNS THEY'RE READY:

- Dribblers easily escaping sharks
- Players looking bored or asking "what's next?"
- Sharks can't catch anyone

SOLUTIONS:

- Make grid smaller (15x15 paces)
- More sharks (1 shark per 4 dribblers)
- Dribblers must stay moving (no standing)
- Weak foot only for dribbling
- Add "super shark" who can use hands to block

Soccer Bowling

BEGINNER · 4–16 PLAYERS · 10 MIN · SMALL SPACE

Knock down cones by passing/shooting - bowling with a soccer ball

1. Each player gets two 'rolls' (shots) to knock down cones 2. One point per cone knocked down 3. Spare (all cones in two shots) = 15 points 4. Strike (all cones in one shot) = 20 points 5. Teams take turns bowling

Equipment: Cones (10), Balls

COACHING POINTS

- Aim for the lead cone
- Strike through the ball
- Follow through to target

COMMON MISTAKES

- Aiming too high
- Toe poking
- Not following through

Variations: Long Distance Bowling (Bowl from further away); Weak Foot Bowling (Must use non-dominant foot)

MAKE IT EASIER

Closer to pins, fewer pins

MAKE IT HARDER

Further from pins, weak foot only

Speed Dribbling Relay

BEGINNER · 8–24 PLAYERS · 10 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Dribbling at speed through cones in team relay format

1. First player dribbles through course and back
2. Tags next player who goes
3. First team to finish wins
4. Vary the dribbling technique required

Equipment: Cones, Balls

COACHING POINTS

- Close control around cones
- Accelerate in open spaces
- Use outside of foot for speed
- Keep head up when possible

COMMON MISTAKES

- Ball too far ahead
- Slowing down too much at cones

Variations: Weak Foot Only (Must use non-dominant foot); Skill Move Required (Must do a move at each cone)

MAKE IT EASIER

Wider cone spacing, shorter course

MAKE IT HARDER

Tighter cones, longer course, add penalties for errors

Traffic Lights

BEGINNER · 4–30 PLAYERS · 5 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Dribbling game where players respond to color commands. Red=stop, Yellow=slow, Green=fast. Develops listening skills, ball control at different speeds, and the foundational ability to stop a ball on command.

Equipment: 1 ball per player, 4 cones (optional)

COACHING POINTS

- STOP WITH SOLE → Say: 'Squash the ball like a bug!'
- GREEN = FAST BUT CONTROLLED → Say: 'Fast feet, but can you still stop on red?'
- HEAD UP FOR COMMANDS → Say: 'Ears open, eyes up!'
- CHANGE DIRECTION → Say: 'Don't just go straight - explore the whole space!'

COMMON MISTAKES

- BALL ROLLS AWAY ON RED → Say: 'Get foot on top quicker! Squash it!'
- SAME SPEED GREEN/YELLOW → Say: 'Show the difference! Green=cheetah, Yellow=turtle'
- NOT SPREADING OUT → Say: 'Find space where you can swing arms without touching anyone'
- ONLY STRAIGHT LINES → Say: 'Explorers! Visit every corner of our space'

Variations: Add Orange/Amber (Orange = medium speed. Now 4 speeds to control.); Traffic Cop (Player becomes traffic cop, calls colors. Rotate every 30 seconds.); Body Part Stop (On RED, call body part (knee, elbow) to touch ball.); Direction Colors (BLUE = turn left, ORANGE = turn right while moving.)

MAKE IT EASIER

SIGNS THEY'RE STRUGGLING:

- Most can't stop on red
- Confusion about colors
- Collisions from lack of control

SOLUTIONS:

- Slow down color calls
- Only green and red first (add yellow later)
- Let ball stop naturally (don't require sole)
- More time between calls

MAKE IT HARDER

SIGNS THEY'RE READY:

- Instant responses
- Perfect stops every time
- Asking "what else?"

SOLUTIONS:

- Call colors faster
- Whisper colors
- Add reverse mode
- Weak foot only on yellow
- Add movements (jumping jacks on red)

Volcano Dribble

BEGINNER · 6–24 PLAYERS · 6 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Dribble around 'volcanos' (cones) without touching them

1. Players dribble freely avoiding the 'volcanos' (cones) 2. If you touch a volcano, it 'erupts' - do 5 toe taps 3. Coach can call 'Lava flow!' - everyone must freeze 4. Keep count of how many times you touched a volcano

Equipment: Cones (15-20), 1 ball per player

COACHING POINTS

- Head up to see the volcanos
- Small touches to change direction
- Use different surfaces of foot

COMMON MISTAKES

- Looking down at ball
- Big touches that lose control

Variations: Moving Volcanos (Some players are 'volcanos' that slowly move)

MAKE IT EASIER

Fewer volcanos, larger spaces

MAKE IT HARDER

More volcanos, smaller spaces, faster pace

World Cup

BEGINNER · 6–20 PLAYERS · 12 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Classic playground elimination game where all players start together, everyone for themselves, trying to score in a central goal. When you score, you're safe. Last players without a goal are eliminated. Develops shooting, dribbling in traffic, and decision-making.

Builds: Shooting

Equipment: 1 ball (extras nearby), 2 cones for goal

COACHING POINTS

- FIND SPACE AWAY FROM CROWD → Say: 'Where is the ball going to pop out? Be there!'
- TAKE YOUR SHOT → Say: 'If you have a chance, shoot! Don't wait!'
- WIN THE BALL → Say: 'Get there first! Be hungry for the ball!'
- QUICK DECISIONS → Say: 'Shoot, dribble, or pass to yourself - decide fast!'

COMMON MISTAKES

- EVERYONE CHASING BALL IN A BUNCH → Say: 'Find space! The ball will pop out - be ready!'
- NOT SHOOTING WHEN THEY HAVE A CHANCE → Say: 'Shoot! You won't score if you don't try!'
- ONLY TRYING TO STEAL → Say: 'Get your own ball - dribble and shoot!'
- GETTING FRUSTRATED → Say: 'Stay calm - your chance will come!'

Variations: World Cup Pairs (Play in pairs (teams of 2). Must combine to score. Both safe when team scores.); Comeback World Cup (Eliminated players do 5 juggles then return. No permanent elimination.); Two Goal World Cup (Add second goal opposite the first. More chances, less crowding.); Keeper World Cup (Eliminated players become keepers in goal. Makes scoring progressively harder.)

MAKE IT EASIER

SIGNS THEY'RE STRUGGLING:

- Same players always eliminated
- Weaker players never touch ball
- Frustration/tears from repeated elimination
- Game dominated by 2-3 strong players

SOLUTIONS:

- Multiple balls in play
- Weak foot goals = instant safe
- 2 goals to spread play out
- "Comeback" - eliminated do 5 ball taps, return
- No permanent elimination (everyone plays every round)
- Pair up weaker with stronger as team

MAKE IT HARDER

SIGNS THEY'RE READY:

- Players scoring easily
- Not enough competition for ball
- Players want more challenge
- Quick rounds

SOLUTIONS:

- Must beat someone 1v1 before shooting
- Weak foot only
- Must score from shooting line
- Eliminated become goalkeepers (progressively harder)
- Smaller goal
- Add time limit ("Score in 2 minutes or eliminated")

World Cup

BEGINNER · 6–16 PLAYERS · 12 MIN · MEDIUM SPACE

Classic knockout shooting game that kids love

1. Coach serves balls randomly into the box 2. Everyone is for themselves - score in the goal 3. First to score 3 goals wins 4. If goalkeeper saves and shouts your name, you're eliminated 5. Can steal ball from anyone

Equipment: Goal, Many balls

COACHING POINTS

- Be first to the ball
- Shoot when you have a chance
- Shield the ball
- Stay alert

COMMON MISTAKES

- Taking too long to shoot
- Not being aware of others

Variations: Must One-Touch (First touch must be a shot); Headers Only (Coach throws balls for headers only)

MAKE IT EASIER

More balls in play

MAKE IT HARDER

Fewer balls, smaller goal

CHAPTER FIVE

Your First Sessions

6 ready-to-run session plans for the fundamentals stage, in the order you'll likely need them: an opening day, ball-mastery basics, dribbling, passing, and a pre-game warmup. Each segment lists what to run and why — adapt the timing to your group size and attention span.

First Day of Season - Getting Started Right

45 MINUTES TOTAL

A 45-minute session designed for the very first practice of the season. Focus on fun, meeting teammates, learning names, and establishing a positive tone. Zero pressure, maximum smiles.

Equipment: 1 ball per player (plus extras), 8-12 cones, Pinnies (2 colors, enough for half the team each), Whistle (optional), First aid kit, Water available

Welcome & Name Game — WARMUP · 8 MIN

Gather the team, introduce yourself, learn names through a fun ball activity

Try: Name Ball Toss, Circle Introduction

Follow the Leader Warmup — WARMUP · 7 MIN

Get bodies moving with a fun follow-the-leader game that requires a ball

Try: Follow the Leader, Simon Says with Balls

Traffic Lights Introduction — TECHNICAL · 10 MIN

Introduce basic ball control through the Traffic Lights game - simple commands, lots of success

Try: Traffic Lights, Red Light Green Light with Balls

Partner Ball Fun — TECHNICAL · 8 MIN

Simple partner activities to start building passing basics and teamwork

Try: Partner Passing, Ball Swap Game

Fun Scrimmage Game — GAME · 10 MIN

Simple small-sided game with cones for goals - first taste of 'real' soccer

Try: 3v3 to Cone Goals, End Zone Game

Celebration & Goodbye — COOLDOWN · 2 MIN

Bring it in, celebrate the first practice, set expectations for next time

Try: Team Chant, High Five Tunnel

Ball Mastery Session - Individual Ball Control

60 MINUTES TOTAL

A 60-minute session focused on developing individual ball control through fun, engaging activities. Players work on toe taps, sole rolls, and basic touches in game-like environments. High repetition, maximum touches on the ball.

Equipment: 1 ball per player (plus extras), 20-25 cones, Pinnies (2 colors), Timer/phone, First aid kit

Free Play Arrival — WARMUP · 5 MIN

As players arrive, they grab a ball and play freely within the marked area

Try: Free dribbling, Juggling attempts, Shooting at cones

Dynamic Warmup - Ball Mastery Circle — WARMUP · 8 MIN

Guided ball touches in a circle formation - toe taps, sole rolls, foundations

Try: Ball Mastery Circle, Toe Taps, Sole Rolls

Ball Mastery Stations — TECHNICAL · 12 MIN

Rotating stations for focused ball mastery practice

Try: Toe Tap Station, Sole Roll Station, Tick Tock Station, Pull Back Station

Traffic Lights Plus — TECHNICAL · 8 MIN

Traffic Lights with added ball mastery challenges on each stop

Try: Traffic Lights with Challenges, Traffic Lights Plus

Cone Knockout Game — GAME · 10 MIN

Dribbling game where players try to knock over cones while protecting their own

Try: Cone Knockout, Dribble & Destroy

Small-Sided Scrimmage — GAME · 12 MIN

3v3 or 4v4 scrimmage applying ball mastery skills in game context

Try: 3v3 to Small Goals, 4v4 End Zone

Cool Down & Ball Mastery Challenge — COOLDOWN · 5 MIN

Light activity, personal challenge setting, and celebration

Try: Juggling Attempts, Personal Best Challenge

Dribbling Adventures - Learning to Move with the Ball

60 MINUTES TOTAL

A 60-minute session focused on dribbling skills through adventure-themed games. Players learn to dribble with different parts of the foot, change direction, and dribble under pressure. High engagement through storytelling and imagination.

Equipment: 1 ball per player (plus extras), 25-30 cones, 20-25 small objects for treasure (extra cones, discs, bean bags), Pinnies (2-3 for sharks), First aid kit

The Jungle Warmup — WARMUP · 8 MIN

Adventure-themed warmup where players dribble like different animals

Try: Animal Dribbling, Jungle Adventure

Dribbling Through Gates — TECHNICAL · 10 MIN

Players dribble through cone gates scattered around the area - different points for different gates

Try: Gates Dribbling, Gate Challenges

Treasure Island — TECHNICAL · 10 MIN

Dribbling game where players collect 'treasures' (cones/objects) while dribbling

Try: Treasure Island, Collect the Cones

Shark Attack — GAME · 10 MIN

Classic dribbling game - sharks try to kick balls out while dribblers protect

Try: Shark Attack, Protect Your Ball

Adventure Scrimmage — GAME · 15 MIN

Small-sided game with special 'adventure points' for dribbling moves

Try: 3v3 Adventure Game, Dribbling Points Scrimmage

Adventure Recap & Challenge — COOLDOWN · 7 MIN

Cool down with adventure recap, skill challenge, and celebration

Try: Juggling Challenge, Adventure Badge Review

Game Day Warmup - Pre-Game Routine

20 MINUTES TOTAL

A focused 20-minute pre-game warmup routine for young players. Gets bodies warm, minds focused, and energy levels right. Simple, consistent routine that becomes familiar throughout the season. Builds confidence before kickoff.

Equipment: 1 ball per player, 4 cones for warmup line, Water bottles (remind parents), This warmup plan

Arrival & Ball Touches — WARMUP · 5 MIN

Free ball play while team assembles, gentle ball touches to settle nerves

Try: Free dribbling, Gentle passing with partner

Team Circle Ball Mastery — WARMUP · 4 MIN

Group ball mastery to synchronize the team and build rhythm together

Try: Toe Taps, Sole Rolls, Tick Tocks

Dynamic Movement — WARMUP · 4 MIN

Jogging and dynamic movements to raise heart rate and loosen muscles

Try: Jog and move, Dynamic stretches, Light running

Passing Pairs — TECHNICAL · 4 MIN

Partner passing to warm up touch and get game-ready connections

Try: Partner passing, Two-touch passing

Team Huddle & Lineup — COOLDOWN · 3 MIN

Final team huddle, starting lineup announcement, team chant for confidence

Try: Team huddle, Starting lineup, Team chant

Ball Mastery Fun Session

60 MINUTES TOTAL

Focus on individual ball control through fun games. Perfect for beginning of season or younger players.

Equipment: 1 ball per player, 20+ cones, 2 mini goals

Free Play Arrival — WARMUP · 5 MIN

Let players arrive and play freely with balls. Coach greets each player by name.

Try: free-play

Warmup: Volcano Dribble — WARMUP · 7 MIN

Players dribble around 'volcanos' (cones) without touching them. If they touch a volcano, it 'erupts' - 5 toe taps!

Try: volcano-dribble

Ball Mastery Circuit — TECHNICAL · 12 MIN

Stations with different ball mastery moves. 2 minutes per station.

Stations: - Station 1: Toe taps (count to 20) - Station 2: Inside-inside touches (side to side) - Station 3: Pull-push with sole - Station 4: Around the world (circles around ball) - Station 5: Tick-tocks (pendulum between feet)

Try: ball-mastery-circle

Shark Attack Game — GAME · 12 MIN

Dribblers try to keep ball while 1-2 'sharks' try to kick balls out of the grid.

Try: shark-attack

Passing Partners — TECHNICAL · 8 MIN

Simple passing with a partner, focus on technique.

Try: passing-pairs

World Cup — FUN · 12 MIN

Everyone starts. Score = stay in. Miss = out and practice on side. Final 4 = World Cup Final!

Try: world-cup

Team High Fives — COOLDOWN · 4 MIN

Gather team, celebrate wins, give high-fives.

Before Practice - Arrive 10 minutes early to set up - Have water available - Prepare all stations before players arrive ## Key Principles for Fundamentals Stage 1. Every player has a ball as much as possible 2. Keep instructions short (30 seconds max) 3. More playing time, less standing time 4. Praise effort, not just results 5. Use questions, not commands ## Parent Communication - Let parents know practice is play-based - Encourage parents to stay and watch - Brief check-in at pickup: one positive thing about each player

First Passing Session

60 MINUTES TOTAL

Introduction to passing with partners. Emphasis on fun and success, not perfection.

Equipment: 1 ball per player, Cones, 4 mini goals

Copy Cat Dribbling — WARMUP · 7 MIN

Coach leads, players copy. Include stops, turns, speed changes.

Try: copy-cat-dribbling

Traffic Lights — WARMUP • 6 MIN

Red = stop, Yellow = slow dribble, Green = fast dribble. Add moves on colors.

Try: traffic-lights

Partner Passing Intro — TECHNICAL • 10 MIN

Partners 5 yards apart. Focus on: plant foot, locked ankle, follow through.

Try: passing-pairs

Passing Accuracy Challenge — TECHNICAL • 10 MIN

Pass through gates of different sizes. Narrow = 3 points, wide = 1 point.

Try: passing-accuracy-challenge

3v1 Rondo Intro — TACTICAL • 12 MIN

Introduce the concept of keep-away. Rotate defender frequently.

Try: 3v1-rondo

3v3 to Small Goals — GAME • 12 MIN

Small-sided game focusing on passing. Award bonus point for 3-pass goal.

Try: 4v4-to-small-goals

Stretch Circle — COOLDOWN · 3 MIN

Simple stretches in a circle. Each player picks a stretch.

Try: passing-pairs

Focus for This Session - Plant foot technique - Locked ankle - Follow through to target ## Common Mistakes to Watch For - Toe poking (not using inside of foot) - Plant foot too far from ball - Not following through ## Differentiation - Struggling players: move closer together - Advanced players: add one-touch requirement

CHAPTER SIX

Talking to Parents

A coach who can explain "why" to a parent — why there's no scoreboard, why every child plays every position, why practice looks like games instead of lines and drills — earns the trust that makes the rest of this book possible.

From Discovery to Fundamentals

Most parents joining a fundamentals-stage (6–8) team remember discovery-stage (3–5) soccer as pure play — no positions, no plan, everyone chasing the ball. That instinct doesn't disappear at six; it gets channeled. The fundamentals stage keeps discovery's core promise (fun first, everyone touching the ball constantly) while layering in the ABCs — agility, balance, coordination, speed — through the same games format, never through lines or lectures. Parents who understand that continuity stop asking "when do we start real practice" and start noticing their child's balance, first touch, and confidence improving every week.

Partnering with Parents: Building Trust and Alignment

How to communicate your development philosophy to parents and get them on board with the journey.

The Parent Challenge

Many parents approach youth sports with good intentions but misguided expectations. They may:

- Overvalue winning and outcomes
- Compare their child to more developed peers
- Provide well-meaning but counterproductive feedback
- Focus on playing time over development
- Project their own sports dreams onto their child

Your job is to **educate and align** parents with a development-focused philosophy.

Start with Transparency

Pre-Season Meeting

Hold a mandatory pre-season meeting to establish expectations:

1. **Your philosophy** (development over winning)
2. **What practices look like** (play-based, age-appropriate)
3. **Playing time expectations** (equal at young ages)
4. **Your communication approach** (how and when you're available)
5. **Their role** (support, not coach)

Provide Resources

Share documents on:

- Age-appropriate development
- What to say (and not say) on the ride home
- How to watch games supportively
- Signs of burnout to watch for

Ongoing Communication

Regular Updates

- Weekly email with practice themes and what you worked on
- Monthly development focuses
- Positive highlights (rotate through all players)

Progress Conversations

- Schedule 1-2 individual player conversations per season
- Focus on development, not outcomes
- Include the player when appropriate (ages 10+)

Game Day Guidance

Before games, remind parents:

- "We're working on [specific focus]. Look for players trying this."
- "Today's success is effort and teamwork, regardless of score."
- "Let them play - no coaching from the sidelines."

Handling Difficult Conversations

"My child isn't playing enough"

"I understand your concern. At this age, equal participation is how players develop. [Child] is getting the same opportunity as everyone else, and I'm seeing growth in [specific area]."

"Why aren't we trying to win?"

"Winning is fun, and we're not trying to lose. But research shows that focusing on development produces better players AND more winning in the long run. Short-term results can hide long-term problems."

"My child is better than others"

"[Child] is doing well in [specific area]. At this age, physical maturity can mask technical gaps. I'm focused on making sure [Child] has the skills needed for the next level, which sometimes means working on weaknesses."

"I disagree with your coaching"

"I'm happy to explain my approach. Can we set up a time to talk this week? I want you to understand why I'm doing what I'm doing."

Setting Boundaries

Sideline Behavior

Be clear about expectations:

- Cheering for effort: ✓
- Coaching from sidelines: ✗
- Criticizing referees: ✗
- Negative comments about players: ✗

The 24-Hour Rule

Establish a cooling-off period for post-game discussions. Emotions run high; decisions are made better with perspective.

What You Won't Discuss

- Other players
- Playing time comparisons
- Team selection decisions
- In-game tactical decisions

The Ride Home

Share research on "The Car Ride Home":

- Ask: "Did you have fun?"
- Ask: "What did you enjoy most?"
- Avoid: Analysis of performance
- Avoid: What they did wrong
- Avoid: What coach should have done

Players whose parents say "I love watching you play" report higher enjoyment and stay in sports longer.

Converting Skeptics

Some parents take time to buy in. Strategies:

- Invite them to watch practice (see your methods)
- Share player improvement stories
- Connect them with aligned parents
- Be patient - results over time win them over

Remember

Parents want what's best for their child. When they trust that you do too, most difficulties dissolve. Build that trust through consistent communication, visible care for players, and genuine expertise.

The Post-Game Conversation: What Parents Should Say

Research-backed guidance on how parents can support their child athlete after competition.

The Most Important Six Words

Research by Bruce Brown and Rob Miller surveyed hundreds of college athletes about their youth sports experiences. The most impactful thing parents can say?

"I love watching you play."

That's it. Not advice. Not analysis. Just unconditional enjoyment of seeing their child compete.

What Athletes Don't Want to Hear

The same research revealed what caused the most negative memories:

- Criticism of their performance
- Criticism of the coach
- Criticism of teammates
- Analysis of what they should have done
- Comparisons to other players

The Optimal Post-Game Conversation

Immediately After the Game

Say: "Did you have fun?"

Purpose: Reinforces that enjoyment matters most

Say: "Are you hungry/thirsty?"

Purpose: Takes care of their physical needs, changes focus

Say: "I'm proud of how hard you worked out there."

Purpose: Reinforces effort over outcome

Later (If They Want to Talk)

Let the child lead. If they want to discuss the game, ask open-ended questions:

- "What was your favorite moment?"
- "What do you want to work on for next time?"
- "How did the team do together?"

What to Avoid

- Detailed analysis of their play
- Comparison to other players
- "Constructive" criticism
- Questions about the coach's decisions
- Your disappointment (even if hidden)

Why This Matters

Performance Anxiety

When children expect post-game criticism, they develop performance anxiety. They play not to fail rather than playing to succeed.

Intrinsic Motivation

Children who receive unconditional support maintain love for the sport longer. Those whose parental approval seems conditional on performance often burn out or quit.

Parent-Child Relationship

Sports should enhance the parent-child bond, not strain it. When games are followed by criticism, children associate the sport with negative emotions.

Common Parent Mistakes

"I'm just trying to help them improve"

Reality: Improvement happens at practice with coaches. The car ride home isn't coaching time.

"They need to hear tough feedback"

Reality: They get plenty of feedback at practice. They need unconditional support at home.

"I played at a high level and know what they need"

Reality: Your expertise doesn't change their emotional needs. Your role now is parent, not coach.

"They seemed upset, I wanted to explain what went wrong"

Reality: Let them process. Being a listening ear beats being an analyst.

The Exception

If your child asks for your feedback or analysis, you can provide it thoughtfully:

- Ask permission: "Do you want my thoughts, or do you just want to vent?"
- Start positive: What they did well

- Be specific and actionable: One thing to work on
- End supportive: Express confidence in them

For Coaches: Help Parents Succeed

Share this guidance with parents:

- Pre-season meeting discussion
- Handout for game day
- Reminder in weekly emails

Parents want to do right by their kids. Many just don't know what that looks like.

Final Thought

Children have the rest of their lives to analyze, strategize, and optimize. For now, they need to feel loved unconditionally while they play a game.

"I love watching you play."

INDEX

Skill Index

- 1v1 Defending, 31
- Agility - Change of Direction, 32
- Agility & Coordination, 33
- Ball Control, 22
- Ball Mastery - Toe Taps, 23
- Coachability, 36
- Confidence, 35
- Dribbling, 27
- Dribbling with Inside/Outside, 26
- Enjoyment of Play, 34
- Finding Space, 29
- Passing (Short), 24
- Receiving / First Touch, 25
- Resilience, 37
- Shooting, 28
- Speed, 34
- Support Play, 30
- Teamwork, 38